

Abul Fazl's Theory of State

Introduction

Abul Fazl (1551–1602) occupies a distinguished position in the history of medieval Indian political thought. He was one of the most important intellectuals, historians, and political thinkers of the Mughal period. He served as a close adviser and court historian of Emperor Akbar and played a significant role in articulating and intellectually justifying Akbar's political philosophy. His ideas on the state, sovereignty, kingship, administration, religion, justice, and social order are mainly found in his two celebrated works, *Akbarnama* and *Ain-i-Akbari*.

Abul Fazl's political thought developed in the context of sixteenth-century India, a period characterised by political expansion, religious diversity, social complexity, and the consolidation of the Mughal Empire. His theory of state cannot be understood merely as an abstract philosophical doctrine. It was closely connected with the practical political requirements of Akbar's empire. Abul Fazl attempted to provide a philosophical and moral foundation for a strong, centralised and just monarchy.

The central concept in his political philosophy is divine kingship. According to him, sovereignty ultimately originates from God, and the king is appointed by divine wisdom to maintain order, justice and prosperity in society. However, the ruler is not simply a divine figure enjoying unlimited personal authority. His legitimacy depends upon his ability to govern with justice, wisdom, tolerance, compassion and concern for the welfare of his subjects.

Abul Fazl's conception of the state therefore combines Islamic political traditions, Persian political ideas, Indian traditions of kingship, Sufi influences and Akbar's practical experience of

governance. His political philosophy emphasised universal peace, religious tolerance, justice, rationality, administrative efficiency and the welfare of all communities.

1. Historical Background of Abul Fazl

Abul Fazl was born in 1551. His father, Shaikh Mubarak, was a well-known scholar. Abul Fazl received a broad education and developed an interest in philosophy, religion, literature and intellectual debates.

He entered Akbar's court and gradually became one of the emperor's closest advisers. He participated in the intellectual and religious discussions organised by Akbar and became an important interpreter of Akbar's political and religious ideas.

His two major works are:

1. Akbarnama – a detailed history of Akbar's reign.
2. Ain-i-Akbari – a systematic account of the organisation, administration, institutions, economy, society and customs of the Mughal Empire.

These works provide valuable material for understanding Abul Fazl's conception of the state.

The political environment of Akbar's reign greatly influenced Abul Fazl's thought. Akbar ruled over a vast and religiously diverse empire containing Muslims, Hindus, Jains, Zoroastrians and followers of other traditions. Therefore, a political system based exclusively on the interests of one religious community was inadequate for maintaining imperial unity. Abul Fazl consequently developed a conception of kingship that emphasised justice, tolerance and universal welfare.

2. Meaning and Nature of the State

For Abul Fazl, the state was an essential institution for maintaining order, justice and human welfare. Human beings require political organisation because society cannot function peacefully without authority and governance.

The state has several important functions:

maintenance of law and order;

protection of subjects;

administration of justice;

defence of the empire;

promotion of economic prosperity;

prevention of oppression;

maintenance of social harmony; and

promotion of the welfare of the people.

Thus, the state was not merely an instrument for the personal power of the monarch. It had a moral and social purpose.

Abul Fazl's ideal state was therefore a well-organised, centralised and just monarchy under the leadership of a wise ruler.

3. Divine Origin of Kingship

The most distinctive feature of Abul Fazl's theory of state is his conception of the divine origin of kingship.

According to him, kingship is a divine institution. God, in His wisdom, establishes a ruler to maintain order among human beings. The ruler receives a special spiritual illumination or divine light, which Abul Fazl refers to through the Persian concept of Farr-i-Izadi or divine splendour/glory.

This idea has roots in ancient Persian political thought. The Persian tradition regarded the legitimate king as possessing a divine radiance or glory that distinguished him from ordinary people.

Abul Fazl adapted this idea to Akbar's political system.

The king was therefore not merely the strongest individual in society. He possessed a special responsibility and authority because divine wisdom had entrusted him with the governance of people.

However, divine kingship should not be interpreted simply as the claim that the king was literally God. Rather, Abul Fazl regarded the ruler as an instrument through which divine justice and order could be realised on earth.

4. The Concept of Farr-i-Izadi

Farr-i-Izadi is one of the central concepts in Abul Fazl's political philosophy.

The term may broadly be understood as divine glory, divine light or heavenly splendour.

According to Abul Fazl, God grants this special illumination to an exceptional ruler. It gives the ruler qualities such as:

wisdom;

courage;

justice;

generosity;

self-control;

administrative ability;

compassion; and

capacity to distinguish right from wrong.

A ruler possessing divine illumination becomes capable of governing society properly.

The concept provided an ideological basis for Akbar's sovereignty. It suggested that Akbar's authority was not dependent merely on conquest, heredity or the approval of religious scholars. His authority had a higher moral and divine foundation.

5. Sovereignty of the Monarch

Abul Fazl believed in strong and centralised monarchy.

The emperor was the supreme political authority of the empire. All important administrative and political institutions operated under his authority.

The need for strong monarchy arose from the conditions of the Mughal Empire. The empire was vast, diverse and composed of numerous ethnic, religious and political groups. A weak central authority could lead to rebellion, factionalism and disorder.

Therefore, Abul Fazl supported a powerful sovereign who could:

maintain unity;

control nobles;

enforce justice;

supervise administration;

protect the empire;

regulate economic affairs; and

maintain peace.

Nevertheless, sovereignty carried a moral responsibility. The emperor was expected to rule according to justice and public welfare.

6. The King as the Centre of the State

In Abul Fazl's conception, the monarch occupied the central position in the political system.

The empire's administrative structure was organised around the emperor. Ministers, nobles, governors and officials derived their authority from the sovereign.

The emperor was expected to supervise the functioning of the administration personally. He had to ensure that officials did not misuse their authority and that subjects received justice.

Thus, Abul Fazl's state was monarchical, centralised and bureaucratic.

The ruler was simultaneously:

the supreme political authority;

protector of the people;

source of justice;

commander of the armed forces;

head of administration; and

guardian of social order.

7. Duties of the King

Although Abul Fazl gave extensive authority to the monarch, he also placed significant moral responsibilities upon him.

The ideal ruler should possess qualities such as:

(a) Justice

Justice was perhaps the most important quality of an ideal ruler.

The king should protect the weak from the powerful and prevent officials from exploiting ordinary people.

(b) Wisdom

The ruler should be intelligent and capable of understanding complicated political and social problems.

(c) Self-control

A ruler should not become a slave to personal passions, anger or greed.

(d) Compassion

The ruler should have sympathy for his subjects and treat them as members of one political community.

(e) Tolerance

The ruler should not discriminate against people on the basis of their religious beliefs.

(f) Protection

The king must protect the empire from internal rebellion and external enemies.

(g) Welfare

The ultimate purpose of good government should be the prosperity and happiness of the people.

Therefore, kingship involved both authority and responsibility.

8. Justice as the Foundation of the State

Justice occupies a central position in Abul Fazl's theory of state.

For him, political authority becomes meaningful only when it is exercised for the establishment of justice.

The ruler must ensure that:

innocent people are protected;

criminals are punished according to law;

officials do not abuse their power;

taxation remains reasonable;

the weak are protected from exploitation; and

disputes are fairly resolved.

Justice was also important for maintaining political stability. If people experienced oppression, they could lose their loyalty to the ruler and rebellion could emerge.

Thus, justice was both a moral principle and a practical requirement of successful government.

9. Welfare of the People

Abul Fazl's political thought contains a strong element of welfare-oriented kingship.

The ruler's greatness was not measured simply by the size of his empire or the strength of his army. A good ruler was one who ensured the prosperity and security of his subjects.

The state should encourage:

agriculture;

trade;

industry;

commerce;

public security;

economic stability; and

efficient administration.

The Ain-i-Akbari provides detailed information about revenue administration, agriculture, military organisation, provincial administration and various social and economic institutions. This demonstrates Abul Fazl's interest in the practical functioning of the state.

10. Religious Tolerance

One of the most significant aspects of Abul Fazl's political philosophy is religious tolerance.

Akbar's empire contained people belonging to many religious traditions. Abul Fazl argued for a political order in which subjects of different religions could live peacefully.

He rejected narrow religious fanaticism and supported the principle of Sulh-i-Kul, meaning universal peace or peace with all.

Under this principle, the ruler should not discriminate between subjects on the basis of religion.

The political importance of Sulh-i-Kul was considerable. It provided a basis for integrating different religious and cultural groups into a single imperial political order.

11. Sulh-i-Kul

Sulh-i-Kul is perhaps the most important practical expression of Abul Fazl's political philosophy.

It literally means "peace with all" or "universal peace."

The principle required the state to maintain equal respect and peaceful relations among different communities.

Its important features included:

religious tolerance;

opposition to sectarian conflict;

equal protection of subjects;

freedom from religious discrimination in governance;

respect for different traditions; and

political unity despite religious diversity.

Sulh-i-Kul transformed the idea of the Mughal state from a narrowly religious monarchy into a more inclusive imperial order.

12. Relationship between Religion and State

Abul Fazl did not advocate a complete separation of religion and politics in the modern secular sense. His political philosophy

remained deeply influenced by religious and spiritual ideas.

However, he opposed the idea that political authority should be controlled entirely by orthodox religious scholars.

He believed that the emperor possessed the responsibility to make political decisions in accordance with reason, justice and the welfare of the empire.

This strengthened the position of the Mughal monarch vis-à-vis the orthodox ulama.

Akbar's political authority consequently became more independent of narrow religious interpretations.

13. Reason and Rationality

Abul Fazl attached considerable importance to reason.

He believed that human beings should use their intellect to distinguish truth from falsehood. Political decisions should therefore not be based exclusively on rigid traditions or sectarian interpretations.

The ruler needed wisdom and rational judgement to govern a complex empire.

Reason was particularly important in dealing with:

administrative questions;

religious diversity;

economic policy;

law and justice;

political conflicts; and

relations among different communities.

This rational element distinguishes Abul Fazl from more orthodox medieval political thinkers.

14. Relation between King and Subjects

Abul Fazl viewed the relationship between the monarch and subjects as involving mutual responsibilities.

The king was expected to provide:

security;

justice;

protection;

prosperity;

good administration; and

social peace.

In return, subjects were expected to:

obey legitimate authority;

remain loyal to the emperor;

pay taxes;

maintain peace; and

contribute to the stability of the empire.

The relationship was therefore not simply based on coercion. It also involved loyalty, justice and welfare.

15. Centralised Administration

Abul Fazl strongly supported a centralised administrative structure.

A large empire required systematic organisation. Akbar's administrative reforms created a hierarchy of officials and provinces under the control of the central government.

The empire was divided into provinces, generally known as Subahs, which were further divided into administrative units.

The central government supervised:

revenue;

military organisation;

justice;

provincial administration;

appointments; and

financial affairs.

This structure reduced the possibility of independent power centres developing within the empire.

16. Bureaucracy and Nobility

The Mughal state depended heavily upon a class of nobles and officials.

Abul Fazl's description of the Mansabdari system in the Ain-i-Akbari illustrates the importance of administrative organisation.

Mansabdars were assigned ranks and responsibilities. Their status and military obligations were connected to the imperial administration.

This system helped Akbar:

control the nobility;

organise the military;

maintain administrative discipline;

reward loyal officials; and

prevent powerful nobles from becoming completely independent.

The system thus strengthened centralised monarchy.

17. Revenue Administration

A strong state required a stable financial system.

Abul Fazl paid considerable attention to revenue administration in the Ain-i-Akbari. The Mughal state depended heavily upon agricultural revenue.

Akbar's revenue reforms attempted to make taxation more systematic and predictable.

Revenue administration was important because it financed:

the army;

administration;

public works;

the royal establishment; and

other functions of government.

Abul Fazl's detailed treatment of revenue shows that his theory of state was not merely philosophical but also concerned with the practical machinery of government.

18. Military Organisation

Defence was another essential responsibility of the state.

The emperor was the supreme commander of the armed forces. The military protected the empire against external enemies and helped maintain internal order.

The Mansabdari system played an important role in military organisation.

Abul Fazl considered military strength necessary for maintaining political stability. However, military power was not an end in itself. It was ultimately supposed to protect peace and justice.

19. Law and Justice

The state had to maintain a system of justice to prevent disorder.

Abul Fazl supported the idea that the ruler should ensure that justice was properly administered throughout the empire.

Judicial administration involved different officials and institutions. The emperor remained the ultimate source of political authority.

Justice had to be accessible and should not become an instrument of oppression.

The ruler was expected to prevent corruption and abuse of authority by officials.

20. Concept of Universal Empire

Abul Fazl's political philosophy was closely connected with Akbar's idea of a universal empire.

Akbar's empire was not conceived simply as a Muslim kingdom. It was an imperial state encompassing diverse peoples and communities.

Abul Fazl therefore emphasised:

political unity;

cultural diversity;

religious tolerance;

universal peace;

loyalty to the emperor; and

welfare of all subjects.

The empire was presented as a political order capable of incorporating different groups without destroying their identities.

21. Political Unity and Diversity

India's diversity was a major challenge to medieval state-building.

Abul Fazl recognised that an empire could not be governed successfully through religious or ethnic exclusion.

He therefore supported a political system that combined:

Unity in political authority + diversity in social and religious life.

The emperor provided the central political unity, while subjects could follow different religious and cultural traditions.

This was one of the most progressive aspects of his political thought.

22. Abul Fazl and the Idea of Secular Governance

It would be inaccurate to describe Abul Fazl's political philosophy as identical to modern secularism. The modern concept of secularism developed under very different historical circumstances.

Nevertheless, his emphasis on religious tolerance, equal treatment of communities and freedom of political authority from narrow sectarian control contains elements that are relevant to the history of secular political thought in India.

His political philosophy moved away from a state governed exclusively according to the interests of one religious community.

23. Criticism of Orthodoxy

Abul Fazl was critical of religious orthodoxy when it interfered with political unity and rational government.

He opposed sectarianism and religious fanaticism because they could create conflict within the empire.

His approach gave the monarch considerable independence from orthodox religious authorities.

This was especially important during Akbar's reign because the emperor was attempting to create a political system that could accommodate diverse religious communities.

24. Akbar as the Ideal Ruler

Abul Fazl presented Akbar as the embodiment of the ideal ruler.

According to his portrayal, Akbar possessed:

wisdom;

courage;

justice;

tolerance;

generosity;

administrative skill;

intellectual curiosity; and

concern for his subjects.

Abul Fazl's writings therefore served both as political theory and as an intellectual justification of Akbar's rule.

His description of Akbar should consequently be read critically because Abul Fazl was an important member of the imperial court and a supporter of the emperor.

25. Moral Character of the Ruler

Abul Fazl attached considerable importance to the personal qualities of the monarch.

A ruler who was greedy, cruel, selfish or dominated by passion could not govern successfully.

The ideal monarch should control his desires and dedicate himself to public duty.

The ruler's personal morality therefore had political consequences. A morally disciplined ruler would be more capable of establishing justice and social peace.

26. State as an Instrument of Social Order

The state had an important role in maintaining social order.

Without political authority, powerful groups could exploit weaker groups, disputes could become violent and economic life could suffer.

The ruler therefore had to establish an environment in which:

people could work peacefully;

trade could develop;

agriculture could flourish;

communities could coexist; and

law could be enforced.

Political stability was thus closely connected with economic and social prosperity.

27. Abul Fazl's Theory of State and Public Welfare

A major strength of Abul Fazl's political thought is the connection between political authority and welfare.

The state was expected to create conditions for the prosperity of its subjects.

This involved:

1. protection of life and property;

2. maintenance of peace;

3. fair taxation;

4. economic development;

5. efficient administration;

6. justice;

7. religious tolerance; and

8. protection against oppression.

Thus, the ruler's success ultimately depended upon the condition of his subjects.

28. Comparison with Medieval Islamic Political Thought

Abul Fazl's theory contains similarities with earlier Islamic political thought, particularly the emphasis on:

justice;

protection;

good governance;

obedience to authority; and

moral responsibility of rulers.

However, he departed from orthodox approaches in significant ways.

He placed greater emphasis on:

reason;

religious tolerance;

universal peace;

imperial integration; and

the independent authority of the monarch.

Therefore, his political philosophy represents a creative synthesis rather than a simple continuation of orthodox Islamic political theory.

29. Persian Influence

Persian political traditions had a major influence on Abul Fazl.

The idea of Farr-i-Izadi came particularly from the ancient Persian conception of royal glory.

The king was regarded as the bearer of divine splendour and as the source of justice and order.

Abul Fazl adapted this tradition to the Mughal political context and used it to strengthen the ideological foundation of Akbar's monarchy.

30. Indian Influences

Abul Fazl's political thought also reflected Indian traditions of kingship.

Indian political thought, especially the traditions associated with Kautilya, emphasised:

the importance of the ruler;

protection of subjects;

maintenance of order;

economic prosperity;

efficient administration; and

welfare of the kingdom.

Although Abul Fazl's theory cannot simply be identified with Kautilya's theory, there are notable similarities in the importance given to administration, statecraft and welfare.

The Mughal political system therefore represented a combination of Persian, Islamic and Indian political traditions.

31. Sufi Influence

Sufi ideas also influenced Abul Fazl's understanding of political authority.

The concepts of spiritual illumination, universal humanity and tolerance contributed to his vision of kingship.

The ruler was expected to rise above narrow personal and sectarian interests and work for the welfare of humanity.

This spiritual dimension gave his political theory a moral character.

32. Critical Evaluation

Abul Fazl's theory of state has several important strengths.

First, it emphasised justice.

Justice was placed at the centre of political authority.

Second, it promoted religious tolerance.

Sulh-i-Kul offered a framework for peaceful coexistence among India's diverse communities.

Third, it supported administrative efficiency.

His writings provide an extraordinarily detailed picture of Mughal administration.

Fourth, it connected authority with responsibility.

The ruler was powerful but was expected to use his power for public welfare.

Fifth, it recognised the importance of rational government.

Abul Fazl did not regard rigid religious orthodoxy as sufficient for governing a complex empire.

33. Limitations of Abul Fazl's Theory

Despite its strengths, Abul Fazl's political philosophy has important limitations.

(a) Excessive concentration of power

His theory placed enormous authority in the hands of the emperor. There were few institutional mechanisms to restrict royal power.

(b) Absence of popular sovereignty

The people did not possess sovereignty in the modern democratic sense.

(c) Divine justification of monarchy

The theory of divine kingship could be used to justify almost unlimited royal authority.

(d) Idealisation of Akbar

Abul Fazl's description of Akbar was highly favourable because of his close association with the emperor.

(e) Lack of modern constitutionalism

There was no concept of representative government, fundamental rights or separation of powers in the modern sense.

Therefore, Abul Fazl's theory should be understood within its sixteenth-century historical context rather than judged entirely by modern democratic standards.

34. Significance of Abul Fazl's Theory

Abul Fazl's theory was significant for the development of Indian political thought because it attempted to create a political philosophy suitable for a religiously and culturally diverse empire.

Its major contributions include:

strengthening the idea of centralised government;

providing an ideological basis for Mughal sovereignty;

developing the principle of Sulh-i-Kul;

promoting religious tolerance;

emphasising justice;

connecting government with welfare;

supporting rational administration; and

integrating different communities into a common political framework.

His political philosophy thus occupies an important position between traditional medieval kingship and later ideas of inclusive governance.

35. Conclusion

Abul Fazl's theory of state represents one of the most sophisticated expressions of medieval Indian political thought. His political philosophy was closely associated with Akbar's imperial project, but it went beyond mere praise of the emperor. He attempted to provide a philosophical explanation of why a strong monarchy was necessary and what moral responsibilities accompanied political power.

At the heart of his theory was the belief in the divine origin and moral purpose of kingship. Through the concept of Farr-i-Izadi, the ruler was understood to possess divine illumination that enabled him to establish justice and order. Yet this divine authority was accompanied by serious obligations. The ideal ruler had to be just, wise, tolerant, compassionate and committed to the welfare of his subjects.

The principle of Sulh-i-Kul, or universal peace, was perhaps his most important contribution. It provided an inclusive political

framework for an empire containing people of different religions and cultural traditions. Abul Fazl sought to replace sectarian politics with a broader conception of imperial unity based on tolerance and peaceful coexistence.

His support for centralised administration, systematic revenue collection, military organisation, bureaucratic control and justice demonstrated that his political thought was both theoretical and practical. Through the Akbarnama and Ain-i-Akbari, he presented an integrated vision of monarchy, administration and social order.

At the same time, his theory remained fundamentally monarchical and did not recognise modern concepts such as popular sovereignty, representative democracy, constitutional limitations on executive power or fundamental rights.

Nevertheless, Abul Fazl remains a major figure in the history of Indian political thought. His synthesis of Persian ideas of divine kingship, Islamic ethical principles, Sufi universalism, Indian traditions of statecraft and Akbar's practical policies produced a distinctive theory of the state. His emphasis on justice, tolerance, rationality, administrative efficiency and welfare makes his political philosophy particularly important for understanding the evolution of ideas of governance and pluralism in medieval India.